



“In the last few years, we have boosted our vaccine portfolio and with the Sanofi partnership we are the second-largest player in India. Our aspiration is to become number one”

M.V. RAMANA

CEO, BRANDED MARKETS
(INDIA AND EMERGING MARKETS),
DR. REDDY'S LABORATORIES



“Reinvesting the Covid windfall presents a challenge, as SII is already the largest vaccine maker globally, and opportunities are limited”

VISHAL MANCHANDA

SENIOR VICE PRESIDENT, INSTITUTIONAL
RESEARCH, SYSTEMATIX GROUP



“Indian vaccine manufacturers are collaborating with biotech firms to develop new technology platforms, enabling large-scale production of high-quality vaccines”

SURESH SUBRAMANIYAN

NATIONAL LIFESCIENCES LEADER, EY
PARTHENON INDIA

according to industry estimates, is currently available only in African countries.

Similarly, Cervavac is approved only in India and available for ₹2,000 per dose (around \$23-24) for the private markets. However, when sold to the Indian government, the price of the vaccine will be substantially lower. The Pneumosil Pneumococcal vaccine is said to be priced at \$2 in low-income countries.

Asked if SII plans to go public, Poonawalla responds in the negative. “If we did, we would likely have to double or triple our prices,” he explains.

BEYOND VACCINES

Manchanda of Systematix believes SII should focus on acquisitions and exploring new business ventures. “Biologics present an attractive area for expansion,” he suggests. The sector is growing rapidly, and is highly capital-intensive, which could allow Serum to deploy its capital productively, he says. However, he points out that acquisition targets are scarce in this sector.

Of course, SII has interests outside vaccines. There is the big push in financial services through Poonawalla Fincorp, known earlier as Magma Fincorp in which the Poonawallas acquired a controlling stake in 2021. In FY24, the company posted a record profit of ₹1,027 crore, an 83% year-on-year (YoY) increase. Its assets under management crossed ₹25,000 crore, while quarterly disbursements reached ₹9,688 crore. However, in FY25, its net profit slumped 81% YoY to ₹62 crore, though AUM jumped 43% YoY to ₹35,631 crore. The firm is focused on digital lending, particularly in the consumer and MSME segments.

Rajesh Pherwani, Founder and Chief Investment Officer of Valcreate Investment Managers LLP, says the company's focus on the mid-to-high-yield segment is particularly important. “This space usually gives better margins compared to low-yield sectors, though it does require tighter control on repayment risks to get good returns on the loan book,” he explains.

FILM FORAY

Last August, the film industry was caught by surprise after a news report revealed that film director Karan Johar was scouting for investors in his companies Dharma Productions and Dharmatic Entertainment. It was rumoured that Johar had reached out to India's conglomerates to sell a majority share in the company.

The reason Johar was looking for investors was not hard to find. Per company database Tofler, Dharma Productions has seen a turbulent few years since the pandemic. Sales plummeted from ₹735 crore in FY20